

Ensembles

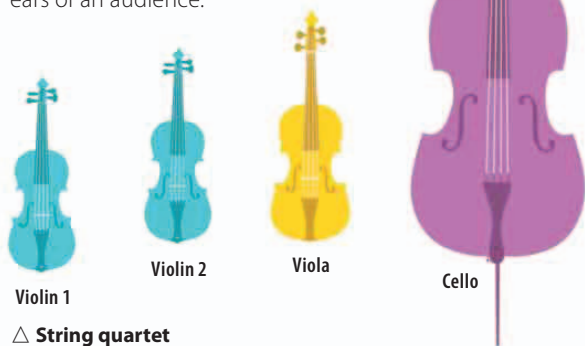
Certain combinations of instruments work particularly well together. This is because their individual sounds blend pleasingly, or because the contrast of different sounds they produce creates varied musical colors and textures.

SEE ALSO

- ◀ 174–175 Strings
- ◀ 176–177 Woodwind
- ◀ 178–179 Brass
- ◀ 180–181 Keyboards
- ◀ 182–183 Percussion

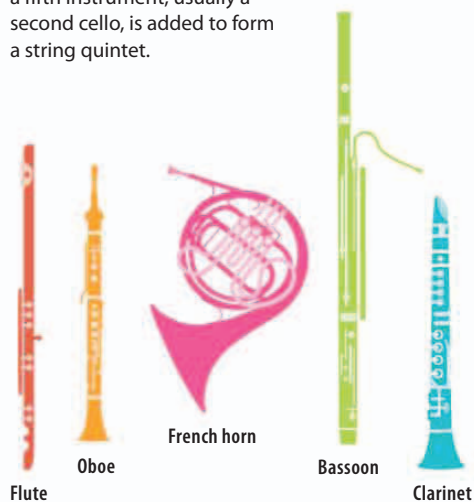
Favorite combinations

Conductors are rarely needed for small ensembles. As a result, the instruments are laid out so that the players can see and hear one another, and ensure the sound produced by the different instruments is blended and well-balanced by the time it reaches the ears of an audience.



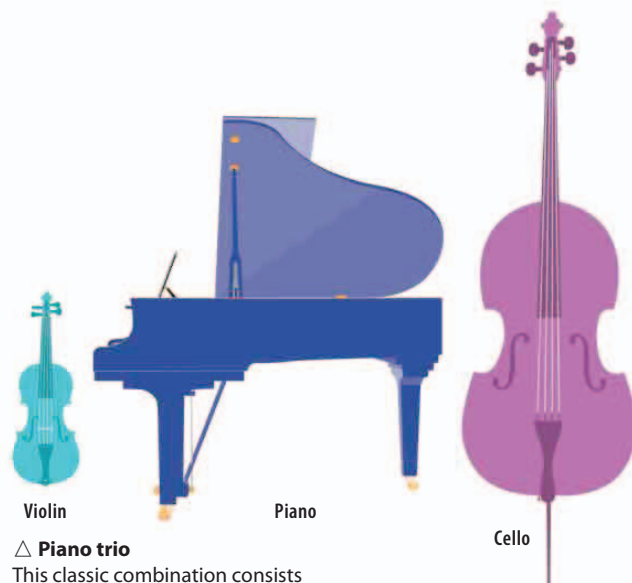
△ String quartet

The two violins, viola, and cello form a string quartet. Sometimes a fifth instrument, usually a second cello, is added to form a string quintet.



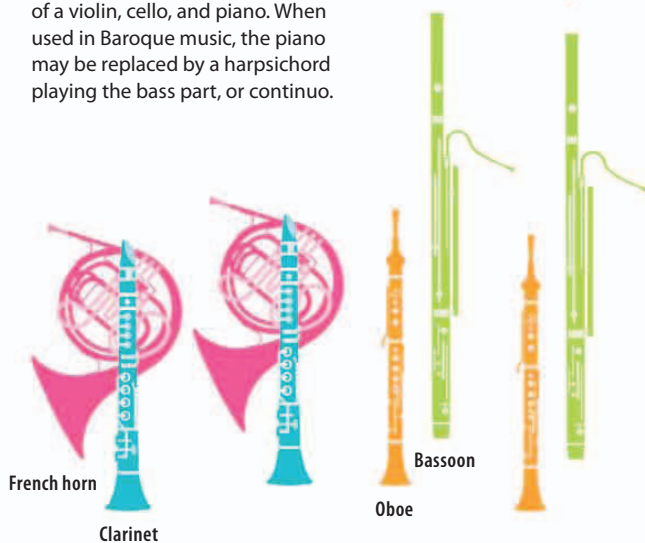
△ Wind quintet

The French horn sits in the center of the semicircle, with the flute and clarinet nearest to the edge of the platform, producing a well-balanced overall sound.



△ Piano trio

This classic combination consists of a violin, cello, and piano. When used in Baroque music, the piano may be replaced by a harpsichord playing the bass part, or continuo.



△ Wind octet

In a wind octet setup, the players sit in pairs, as they do in an orchestra. They either sit in two rows, or in a semicircle of eight if space permits.